the words that need to be said

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by n7punk

Summary

t’ s been a long battle, a longer day, and finally stepping foot back in Bright Moon means finding a place for Catra to sleep. Adora’s nervous to show Catra her room, but more nervous of Catra turning away from it.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

When they arrived in Bright Moon, it was shockingly similar to how they left it. The city and palace were largely empty, but Horde Prime's efforts had been focused elsewhere and the structural damage had not been immense. The wave of magic had caused a burst of plant growth all over the town that would need to be tamed, but the castle was largely the same except for ghosts of the occupation. Furniture had been totally removed from some places, strange tech left in their place, and the library and armoury were thoroughly ransacked, but many rooms seemed to have been searched for anything of use and abandoned. The bedrooms were inspected and found invaded but undamaged. Further efforts at restoration could wait—it had taken all day to reach Bright Moon and begin assigning shelter to those that had made the journey back already.

Adora's door, despite its enormous size, closed behind them with only a soft thud. Adora could feel a tension building in Catra's body despite the only point of contact between them being her grip on the other girl's wrist. She turned to face Catra, smiling a bit nervously as she motioned with her free hand.

"And, uh, this is my room," she explained, as if Catra didn't already know that—as if Glimmer hadn't offered her a faux-apology about the shortage of guest rooms just minutes ago. She hadn't bothered hiding her knowing smirk as she apologized for Catra having to room with somebody else, eyes already fixed on Adora over Catra's shoulder.

"It's big," Catra offers, her voice barely above a whisper.

Adora's gaze flicked to Melog—the creature was wrapped around Catra's legs but seemed curious, relaxed, maybe this was okay?—before settling on Catra's open expression. Catra wasn't looking at Adora in return—her ears were down but not tensed, her eyes a little wide as they swept the room. Wonder, maybe? Adora could not miss how Catra lingered on certain features. Even with her back to the room, Adora knew Catra's sweeping gaze was landing on the

windows and openings, scanning for danger. But she didn't look afraid—it was like she was merely cataloguing her options, the risks, before her eyes truly began to settle on points at eye level. Adora glanced over her shoulder, following her gaze. It stuck on the vanity, open and apparently ransacked, before landing on the bed, off kilter inside of its canopy. Drawings, notes, and battle plans used to be pinned to the inside of the curtain, but only torn paper stubs and small rips in the cloth remained now—all her accumulated plans and memories just another victim of the occupation. Finally, with some confusion, Catra found her way to the floating points above the still pool where a waterfall used to flow, before the release of magic had caused wild plants to bloom and drip down in place of water, vines curling in sheets over the openings to the balcony. Melog padded away from their companion, sniffing idly at the floor as they explored the room. When Adora looked back at Catra, she bit her lip.

Catra's ears had gone from being simply downturned to plastered against her head. The tension in her body seemed to be balling up, pooling in her shoulders as her gaze flicked about the room. "So, this is where you spent your time, huh?" she offered, her soft rasp a bit anxious.

Adora felt a surge of memories—lying on the floor, the bed, sitting on the edge of the pool, all while thinking of Catra, all while worrying what edge this conflict might tip them over. She had imagined the other girl miles away in the Fright Zone, victim to the same thoughts and worries. She couldn't help but wonder now what Catra's side of it had really looked like.

Adora pushed her memories down, offering Catra a small, hopeful smile. She tugged gently on Catra's wrist, and the tension that had seeped into her shoulders eased as she let herself be led deeper into the room. Even to Adora, the room had once seemed imposing, filled with shadows threatening to materialize into threats at any moment. She understood Catra's anxiety, at least a little bit. Adora sat on the edge of her bed slowly, placing one hand on the space beside her, inviting even as she failed to let go of Catra's arm. Sitting

beside her would require it to twist at an awkward angle, but she was scared of what might happen if she let go. She couldn't miss the way Catra's eyes flicked from her face, to her hand on the bed, to her hand on her wrist - before she finally screwed her face up with an adorable look of determination.

Catra sat down on the bed next to her, face and shoulders still bunched up for a moment before she let out a deliberate breath and turned her face toward Adora's. Ears once again down, but relaxed. The canopy draped around the bed, mercifully largely intact, and fell around them as a curtain against the room so filled with darkness and traces of invasion. Moog softly padded closer, thudding against the bedframe as they laid beside it.

"You know, even when I was Force Captain all I had was a broom closet with privacy. I see now why I couldn't lure you back to the Horde," Catra joked, eyes skittering across the room for a moment before meeting Adora's again. Her shoulders were growing tense again.

"*You* know," Adora countered, letting go of Catra's wrist to intertwine their fingers together instead, "I couldn't even sleep in this room at first. I destroyed the bed on the first night. I had to sleep with Bow and Glimmer to get through the first few nights away from the Horde." She hoped the *without you* was implied.

Catra laughed, a sound filled with light that made Adora's entire body feel like it had gone weightless for a moment. For the last few years, that beautiful sound had been shards of glass that cut Adora to her core when she heard the mirth and anger contained within. Now, Catra gazed back at her with a fondness that made it hard to breathe.

"I know. Sparkles told me a bit while we were... on the Horde ship," Catra offered. She avoided his name, avoided the circumstances, but that was fine with Adora if it kept her from locking up right now. They had time. Something in Catra's face softened, but it was

vulnerable, almost scared. Adora felt a small crystal of ice and worry grow in her chest.

"I always wondered what you would say if you could see this. Probably scoff at it. Bright Moon is a bit.. it's just a lot. I'm sorry there aren't enough rooms. I know this might be too much," Adora acknowledged. She felt a pit of dread open in her stomach as anxiety spread across Catra's face, confirming her fears. "Even if the other rooms are full, I'm sure we could find another bedroll. You- you don't have to stay in the same bed if you don't want," Adora managed, turning her gaze to stare at the floor, but unable to turn her body away from Catra. Melog's tail thumped rhythmically on the floor, slow but anxious.

"Is that what you want?" Catra asked, whisper soft. Adora winced – there was nothing accusatory in Catra's voice, but the waver was so much worse.

"If it's what would make you comfortable. I don't want to push you," Adora responded, gaze still fixed on the floor. Melog's tail stilled. They turned their head, blue eyes appearing over the edge of the bed to look at Adora with their soft gaze.

"Adora, look at me." Adora couldn't refuse, not Catra. She should have expected it by now, but her breath still caught when her eyes landed on Catra. Her hair was a mess – from battle, from hugs, from celebratory ruffling. Her ears were fluffed up a bit, the way they used to when she was determined – maybe still did? Adora had the time to find out again – and her eyes were open wide, gleaming in the low moonlight that trickled in between the vines swinging outside the windows. Her expression was raw. There was fear, hope, a pleading look that made Adora's heart break in two. Still, she looked beautiful. "Stop talking like it's for me, Adora. You don't know what I'm thinking. What do you want?" Catra asked again.

Adora let out the breath she had been holding. Carefully, afraid she might spook her, she reached out with her right hand, landing it on Catra's cheek. Her fingers hooked behind Catra's soft ears, gently

stroked the fur there. In the palm of her hand, she could feel a small, involuntary purr start in Catra's throat at the attention to the neglected spot, only recently exposed to such touches.

"I want you to stay. I want you," she admitted in a whisper, like if anyone else in the universe heard they would take her wish away from her. Maybe they would.

The purr became a rumbling. Catra was moving before Adora had time to register that she had extracted herself from the gentle ministrations. She pushed herself on top of Adora, tucking herself against the taller girl's chest before Adora's back had even hit the mattress. Propping herself up on her forearms, Catra gazed down at her, eyes soft. Adora didn't let herself hesitate again – she raised her arms to wrap them around Catra, pulling the other girl tighter to her chest, until she almost felt as if the purr was radiating from her own chest too. They were nose to nose before Adora tilted her head up to seal their mouths together. The kiss only lasted a moment before she had to pull back to giggle.

"Hey!" Catra demanded, quiet and blushing. She pulled away, sitting back with her arms crossed across her chest, but remained straddled across Adora.

"I'm sorry it's just – the purr, it tickles when kissing you," Adora admitted, shoulders still shaking. Even in the dark of the canopied bed, Adora could see the deep flush heat Catra's cheeks. Her fur fluffed up a bit in indignation.

"Well, in- in the morning you're going to get us more pillows. So we can make another bed," she countered, face hot as she sulked backwards. Adora felt her entire chest constrict.

"Catra- no, I was just-" Adora started, before Catra heaved a sigh and reached out one hand, pushing against Adora's chest. She rolled her eyes as Adora fell back against the bed, not even having realized she was rising to reach for the other girl.

"For Mog, dummy. It's called distracting you. There's not enough room in your bed for all three of us. They deserve somewhere comfortable too," Catra elaborated, maintaining eye contact as she laid herself back down atop Adora, spreading out her limbs in a shaky stretch.

"Oh- I- Of course. First thing," Adora promised, relief flushing her face red as she gratefully wrapped her arms around Catra again.

"What, are you worried about losing me or something?" Catra taunted, but her voice was fond and warm.

"Terrified," Adora responded truthfully, though her relief kept any real fear from entering her voice. She tightened her grip on her – best friend? Girlfriend? – as the soft purr began to return.

They were both still fully clothed, shoes included - for Adora, at least. They weren't filthy, but the rebel camp hadn't afforded for the best showers before they had charged into battle against Horde Prime. Still, neither of them made a move from the bed. Eventually, they would pitch sideways to curl into each other as they fell into sleep, but neither of them would leave the bed until the morning sun had made itself known.

In the morning, Catra would make good on her demand for a mountain of pillows. In the search, Catra would catch a glimpse of a real Bright Moon bed and point an accusatory finger at Adora.

"You can't even stop sacrificing in your sleep? You could have had *that* and you've been sleeping on a cot this whole time?" she demanded, unoffended but exasperated. Adora would catch her hand and intertwine their fingers while she laughed at her indignation. Catra would let go of her huff - *but not because I like you*.

Over the next few days, the Princesses and rebellion members that had been forced to crash in Bright Moon for the night would embark back to their homes to begin recovery efforts in their own kingdoms,

and a proper, fluffy bed would mysteriously appear in Adora's room, large enough to hold two people—and a space cat. With Catra curled around her, Adora learned to relax into the softness.

End Notes

The bed stuff at the end is inspired by this post but Is2g that Noelle & Molly talked about how Catra would be good for helping Adora learn to relax on the stream as well.
This is also the first fanfiction I've written in many years so please be gentle. I'm working on more because my Catradora brain rot won't let me go but I'm not sure when I'll be posting them.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!